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A SESSION FOR ONE

# The Solo *Hot Seat*

*Twenty-five minutes with the questions nobody asks you anymore.*

A self-guided session from the room where founders answer the second question, not the first one. Pen and paper required. Performance optional, and unwelcome.

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## BEFORE YOU BEGIN

# The questions *stopped*

I started my first company at thirteen, and I've spent most of my life since then being the person other people bring their problems to. It took me a long time to notice what that arrangement was costing me. When we build something real, the people around us slowly stop asking us real questions. Our teams bring us problems shaped like requests. Our friends ask how business is going and accept the first answer we give. The people who love us most learn to quit pushing, because we're the strong ones, and the strong ones are always fine.

I run a room where that arrangement doesn't hold. Founders, no audience to perform for, and questions that don't accept the first answer. I've watched what happens to a person the moment somebody asks the thing everyone else has been too polite, or too impressed, to ask. It isn't comfortable. It's also the most valuable hour of their month, and they'll tell you the same.

This is a piece of that room, for one. Not a workbook, and not a strategy exercise. A session. I'd treat it the way I'd ask a member to treat the real thing: phone in another room, door closed, pen on paper, twenty-five minutes where nothing needs anything from you.

There are three rounds. They get harder. That's on purpose.

*You're allowed to write things here that no one will ever read. That's the point.*

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**PEN AND PAPER**

Print this, or keep a notebook beside it. The writing happens by hand.

**TWENTY-FIVE MINUTES**

On the calendar, like a meeting. Because it is one.

**A CLOSED DOOR**

Phone in another room. Nobody performs for an empty audience.



## THE RULES OF THE ROOM

# How we do this *in there*

- 1 **Answer the question that was asked.** When I dodge, I dodge toward something more comfortable, and comfort isn't why we're here.
- 2 **The first answer is the practiced one.** In the room we ask the same question twice. Write your first answer, then ask yourself what's truer than that, and write again.
- 3 **Write by hand.** Typing is how we perform. Handwriting is slower, and slower is more honest.
- 4 **Witness, don't fix.** No action items until the session is over. We look first. The fixing goes better when it comes second.
- 5 **The last one gets said out loud.** The session ends with a sentence spoken, not just written. It'll make sense when we get there.

## TWO MINUTES, BODY FIRST

Every session I run starts in the body, because the body doesn't perform. Here's my version, and I'd do it before reading a single question.

I sit. Feet flat on the floor, hands on my knees. I close my eyes and breathe in slowly through my nose, and I let the exhale run longer than the inhale. I do that three times. Then I ask my body where it's holding, and I wait for the actual answer. Jaw, shoulders, chest, gut, wherever it is. I don't fix it. I just let it be found. One more slow breath, and I open my eyes.

*Two minutes. Then begin.*



## ROUND ONE

# Where you *actually* are

In the room, the questions come plainly, and they're allowed to be simple. Simple is not the same as easy.

## 01

When someone asks how business is going, what answer do you give?

Write it down, word for word. Then write the true one underneath it. Notice the distance between the two.

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## 02

What does last week's calendar say you believe matters most?

Not what you'd like to believe. What the hours say. *Your calendar doesn't lie.*

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## 03

When was the last time someone asked you a question you couldn't answer smoothly?

What was the question? Who asked it? If nothing comes to mind, write down how long it's been, and sit with that number for a second.

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## ROUND TWO

# What it's *costing*

This round goes slower. I'd let it. If the drop-in wore off, do it again before the next question.

04

What is the business costing the people closest to you?

Answer it. Then ask the harder version: would they agree with your answer, or would theirs be worse?

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05

What have you been calling a season that has quietly become your life?

Every founder I know has one. The launch that never de-launched. The sprint entering its third year. Name yours.

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06

Where does the pressure live in your body, and how long has it lived there?

You found it in the drop-in. Jaw, shoulders, chest, gut. Write down when it moved in. Most of us can date it more precisely than we expect.

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## ROUND THREE

# The thing you're *not saying*

Two questions left before the last one. In the room, this is where it gets quiet.

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## What do you already know you need to do?

You don't need more information, and you know it. Write the thing. Then write how long you've known. The second number matters more than the first answer.

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08

## Who are you when you're not the strong one?

And when did somebody last get to meet that person? A name and a date, if you can manage it.

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*Human being, not human doing.*



## THE LAST QUESTION

Say it *out loud*

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What's the sentence you've been avoiding saying out loud?

One sentence. Not a paragraph, not a plan. The one you already heard in your head somewhere around question four.

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Now, and I mean this literally, say it out loud. Alone in the room, at whatever volume you can manage. Something happens when a thing we've only carried finally gets spoken, even to nobody. The sentence doesn't get heavier out in the air. It gets lighter.

In the room, that sentence is where the session starts, not where it ends. It's the raw material. The hour that follows it, with people who've said their own version and won't flinch at yours, is the part I can't put in a PDF.

And if you want a witness sooner than that, reply to the email that delivered this session and tell me what you said. You don't owe me context or a paragraph. The sentence is enough, and I read every one.

*No secrets. Know peace.*





WHAT THE ROOM IS

## Now imagine you weren't *alone*

What you just did by yourself, at maybe a fifth of its real intensity, is what happens in the **Royals Mastermind** every time we gather. The difference is the room. Founders who've earned the right to ask you these questions, who can't be impressed by you, and who won't accept the practiced answer, because they gave up their own practiced answers a long time ago.

It's not for everyone, and it might not be for you. The honest way to find out is a conversation, not a pitch. Start with the assessment at [ericfarewell.com](https://ericfarewell.com), and if the room seems like it might be yours, we'll talk.

Whatever you decide, keep the sentence you wrote today. And when you're ready, say it to one person who loves you. That's the whole practice. The tool is community. The tool is sharing. The tool is relationships.

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